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DAYS AFTER THE India AI Impact Summit in New Delhi, and fresh from the launch of Indus—a conversational interface—Vivek Raghavan enters the meeting with *BT* in his Bengaluru office in high spirits. The co-founder of Sarvam AI appears relaxed and quietly pleased—the company, after all, unveiled India’s first foundational AI models during the summit.

But our conversation quickly moves beyond product momentum to something far more consequential. “Sovereignty is important in the long run,” he says. “It’s not about what we build today, tomorrow, or even 10 years from now. You have to look at the long arc.” He is blunt. Without domestic AI capability, India risks becoming merely a consumer in a future shaped elsewhere, a new form of “technological colonisation.”

That long arc started taking tangible shape at the summit, one of the largest global AI gatherings, which drew delegations from over 100 countries. There, Sarvam unveiled the first homegrown foundational models—Sarvam-30B and Sarvam-105B—built from scratch for India’s scale and diversity. Designed using a mixture-of-experts architecture for high efficiency, the models sup-

port more than 22 Indian languages and have been built with a clear premise—AI must work for India’s 1.4 billion people, across languages, voice interfaces, and real-world applications. A mixture-of-experts is a neural architecture that increases efficiency by activating only a subset of experts for an input rather than the entire model.

The ambition is to move beyond elite, English-first AI and build for Bharat. But in a landscape dominated by global heavyweights such as OpenAI, Google, and Anthropic, what will it take for India’s sovereign AI push to move from technological capability to sustained strategic and economic relevance?

According to the Stanford University 2025 Global AI Vibrancy Tool, India ranks third globally in AI competitiveness, after the US and China.

TRUE SOVEREIGNTY

Real AI sovereignty is not just about building models. It requires control over the entire stack right from data and algorithms to compute infrastructure and hardware. Without making their own graphic processing units (GPUs), countries will remain hostage to export restrictions, undermining technological independence. At the same time, sovereignty is not only about hardware. Only a model trained on domestic, culturally relevant data and governed by local regulations—especially when deployed within controlled environments—can retain sovereignty over its behaviour, privacy, and output.

For Raghavan, the challenge is best understood as a layered problem. “The most fundamental layer is energy. Running AI efficiently will increasingly depend on power availability, which is why smaller, more efficient models that consume

Sarvam was the first start-up to receive support under the IndiaAI Mission, the government’s ₹10,370 crore programme aimed at building indigenous AI capabilities